differences, relatively normal diplomatic and cultural relations, and even discussion concerning defence cooperation against China.

At the same time, Pakistan's employment of non-state actors has a long history. It began with the use of tribal lashkars to invade Jammu and Kashmir in 1947. In the 1960s, Brigadier A.A.K. Niazi (who would later achieve notoriety for surrendering at Dhaka in 1971) wrote of 'battlefields of the future' requiring infiltration to cause maximum disorder among enemy forces, part of the Pakistani military establishment's long tradition of thinking systematically about asymmetric and covert warfare. The use of non-state militias continued: in addition to Operation Gibraltar in 1965, Pakistan employed state-supported Islamist proxies to suppress pro-Independence Bangladeshi forces in 1971. The use by Pakistan of non-state actors in Afghanistan similarly pre-dates the Soviet invasion of 1979. [15] But after that period, Pakistan's material and political support for terrorists targeting India—including Khalistani and Kashmiri separatists and members of criminal syndicates—increased dramatically.

In 1989, ISI officers informed Pakistan's new Prime Minister Benazir Bhutto that they would use covert jihad in Kashmir, as they had done to considerable success against Soviet forces in Afghanistan. The ISI's S-Wing —in charge of covert paramilitary operations—organized training camps for militants, where they were armed with Chinese-made weapons and often trained side-by-side with Arabs. After arming and training these and other militants, the ISI helped to infiltrate them into India across the Line of Control, including under covering fire provided by the Pakistan Army. [16] Among the groups supported by the Pakistan Army and ISI over the years are Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT), Jaish-e-Mohammed (JeM), Hizbul Mujahideen, and the Haqqani Network. While many of these groups have been provided financing, arms, ammunition, other equipment (such as radio sets) and training by the Pakistani state security apparatus, they have also benefited from an enabling environment—a safe space—to organise, recruit, arm, train, and fundraise. [17]

The 1980s added a further element to Pakistan's asymmetric and sub-conventional warfare with India: a nuclear deterrent. From the 1970s,